unable to describe them, much less to construct anything like them.' Alberuni wrote a thick tome on India full of fascinating insights and opinions on Indian culture and society.

The Life of Alberuni

In 1017 CE, a king of the Mamuni Dynasty ruled in Khiva (Uzbekistan). In his court was a forty-four-year-old Persian scholar and polymath named Alberuni. A native of the region, he served as a political adviser and astronomer-astrologer. 'Possessing a profound and original mind of encyclopaedia scope', Alberuni was fluent in five languages and excelled in mathematics, physics, mineralogy, medicine, philosophy, history, geography and many more disciplines.[2]

Alberuni's life would change dramatically that year. A thousand miles away in Ghazni (Afghanistan), a warrior-king named Mahmud, a relative of the Mamuni king, was plotting against Khiva. Mahmud belonged to the Ghaznavid Dynasty of Sunni Turks in a largely Persianate culture. They had emerged from the military ethos of the ghazis—a dedicated warrior class raised to guard the north-eastern frontiers of the Abbasid Caliphate. In the summer of 1017, Mahmud of Ghazni invaded and plundered Khiva and returned home with much booty and 'the leading men of the country as prisoners of war or as hostages'.[3] Among the latter was Alberuni himself.

By then, Mahmud was already infamous. Since 1001 CE, he had been raiding India almost annually. His 'targets were the richest temples', writes Romila Thapar, which hoarded gold and revenue from their lands, endowments and pilgrim donations. 'The destruction of temples even by Hindu rulers was not unknown, but [Mahmud] inaugurated an increase in temple destruction compared to earlier times.' He was also a religious fanatic. He raided temple towns like Mathura, Thanesar, Kannauj and Somnath. Twice, Mahmud also 'waged hostilities against Multan, whose ruler, Daud, was an Ismaili' and so the 'wrong' kind of Muslim.[4] Mahmud even desecrated a Shia mosque in Multan and killed many Muslim 'heretics'.[5] He was bad news not just for the Hindus.